

Everybody has a drawer of things they never sent. This is a book about sending them.

Somebody at work has lost their father and you have been staring at an empty message box for two days. A friend has been diagnosed with something serious. You owe an apology you have been avoiding for a month, you need to ask for money, or you have to say no to somebody who will take it badly.

These are the letters nobody teaches you to write, and the reason they go unwritten is almost never that people do not care. It is the fear of getting it wrong, which reliably produces the one outcome that is definitely wrong.

Sixty letters, written out in full, for the occasions that arrive without warning. Each one comes with the situation it answers and a short note on what is actually doing the work: which sentence carries the weight, what has deliberately been left out, and why the paragraph you would have added is the one to cut.

“A colleague’s father has died. You met him twice.”

Condolence, at a distance

WHAT IS DOING THE WORK Say the death out loud, offer one concrete thing, and do not ask them to reply. The commonest mistake is a letter that gives the bereaved a job.

60 LETTERS · 12 CHAPTERS · 6 PARTS



What to Say

LETTERS FOR HARD MOMENTS

What to Say

Sixty letters for the moments nobody teaches you how to write.

60 LETTERS · 12 CHAPTERS